sharpening caste identities—as represented by Mayawati's Dalit-dominated Bahujan Samaj Party and Mulayam's Samajwadi Party—appeared to have a more enduring appeal. Mandal had outlasted mandir in the electoral battlefield.

In the 2009 elections, the BJP won just ten of UP's eighty seats in the Lok Sabha, its worst performance in twenty years. In the 2012 assembly elections, things only got worse for the party. The BJP won just forty-seven of the 403 seats and got a mere 15 per cent of the vote share. I remember meeting a veteran BJP leader from UP after the assembly results who looked totally despondent. *'Sab kuch khatam ho gaya. Ab bas Mulayam aur Mayawati ka khel chalega'* (It is all over for us. Only Mulayam and Mayawati will rule UP now), was his verdict.

Modi's own role in the 2012 UP elections had proved controversial. He refused to campaign in the state in protest against the party choosing his great rival Sanjay Joshi to handle the campaign. Joshi had been hand-picked by the BJP president Gadkari, with the RSS supporting the move. Modi would have none of it. I was privy to a phone conversation where Gadkari was literally pleading with Modi to at least address some rallies in UP since his absence was sending out the wrong message to the cadres. A defiant Modi refused to relent.

I remember telephoning Modi that night to find out why he was so insistent on not going to UP to campaign. I even 'advised' him that as a senior leader he was making a mistake by refusing to campaign in a crucial state. *'Jab tak woh aadmi wahan hai, mere campaign karne ka sawaal hee nahi uthta!'* (As long as that man [Joshi] is there, there is no question of my campaigning.)

Four months after the 2012 UP elections, Joshi was removed from the BJP national executive and almost banished from the party. I asked Gadkari why he had buckled so easily to Modi's determination to isolate Joshi. *'Arre, Rajdeepji, aap Modiji ka swabhaav jaante hai, unka mind badalna aasan nahi!'* (You know Modi's nature, getting him to change his mind is not easy.)